Nicolas Eschenbaum

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Zürich, Switzerland

Economist and competition expert in industrial organization and competition policy, with a focus on algorithmic pricing, digital markets, and AI. I regularly prepare expert reports and provide economic analysis in competition cases and regulatory proceedings, and lead applied and academic research combining game theory, empirical methods, and machine learning.

Positions

2026–present **Managing Economist and AI Lead**, Swiss Economics
Junior partner (shareholder) and member of the executive board. Leading work on AI, digital markets, and competition policy in client and research projects.

2022–2025 **Senior Economist**, Swiss Economics
Economic analysis in competition, digital-markets, and energy projects.

2025–present **Member, Working Group AI/Algorithms**, Academic Society for Competition Law (ASCOLA)
Interdisciplinary work on the legal and policy implications of AI and algorithmic systems in competition law.

2022–present **Collaborator**, Institute for Categorical Cybernetics
Research collaboration on formal and computational approaches to governance, digital systems, and market design.

2024–present **Affiliated Researcher**, Zurich Center for Market Design, University of Zurich
Research on AI and agent-based models, with applications to energy markets.

2024–2025 **Global Fellow**, European AI & Society Fund
Research on foundation models and competition policy.

2018–2024 **Lecturer**, University of St. Gallen
Teaching in industrial organization, digitalization, and competition policy.

2018–2022 **Postdoctoral Researcher**, University of St. Gallen
Research on algorithmic pricing and competition in digital markets, funded by SNSF grant "Pricing in a Digital World."

Education

2013–2018 **Ph.D. in Economics and Finance**, University of St. Gallen
Summa cum laude. Dissertation: *Essays in Industrial Organization*. Supervisor: Prof. Stefan Bühler.

2011–2012 **M.Sc. in Economics**, University of Edinburgh
With distinction.

2008–2011 **B.Sc. in Business and Economics**, Maastricht University

Research Visits

2020–2021 **Visiting Scholar**, Düsseldorf Institute for Competition Economics (DICE)
Invited by Prof. Justus Haucap.

Publications

Journal articles

Picht PG, Nenadic L, Barnes O, **Eschenbaum N**, Kuster Y. "Selective Confusion: An Empirical Analysis of the DMA's Brussels Effect." *World Competition*, 49(3), 445–470, 2026. link

Greber N, **Eschenbaum N**, Szehr O. "Peer-to-Peer Electricity Platforms with Endogenous Prices: A Multi-Agent Neural Network Control Approach." *Energy and AI*, 2026.

Funk M, Rutz S, **Eschenbaum N**. "Kehrtwende in der Missbrauchskontrolle – wie der Neuanfang gelingen kann." *Schweizerische Zeitschrift für Kartell- und Wettbewerbsrecht (SZKW)*, no. 2, 2026.

Picht PG, Nenadic L, Barnes O, **Eschenbaum N**, Kuster Y. "DMA (Verw-)Irrungen: Was die territorialen Umsetzungsstrategien der Torwächter über den Digital Markets Act lehren." *Schweizerische Zeitschrift für Wirtschafts- und Finanzmarktrecht (SZW)*, no. 4, 2025. link

Picht PG, Nenadic L, Barnes O, **Eschenbaum N**, Kuster Y. "Schweizer DMA-Brussels-Effect? Wie Gatekeeper den DMA in der Schweiz (nicht) umsetzen." *sic! Zeitschrift für Immaterialgüter-, Informations- und Wettbewerbsrecht*, no. 1, 3–14, 2025. link

Buehler S, **Eschenbaum N**. "Explaining Escalating Prices and Fines: A Unified Approach." *Journal of Economic Behavior & Organization*, 171, 153–164, 2020. link

Working papers

Greber N, **Eschenbaum N**. "Market Power of Digital Energy Intermediaries: A Framework for Identifying Competition Risks." 2026 (presented at IEEE PES ISGT). link

Eschenbaum N, Meylahn JM. "Auditing Algorithmic Collusion from Strategy Graphs." 2026. link

Eschenbaum N. "Shared Bidding Algorithms and Competition: Evidence from Electricity Markets." 2026. link

Cheng TK, **Eschenbaum N**, Picht PG, Talluri K. "Algorithmic Pricing and Collusion in Practice." Working paper, 2026.

Eschenbaum N, Greber N. "Market Power and Platform Design in Decentralized Electricity Trading." 2026. link

Buehler S, **Eschenbaum N**, Lenhard S. "A Unified Framework for Dynamic Monopoly Pricing: Trading-Up." 2026. link

Buehler S, Epper T, **Eschenbaum N**, Koch R. "Dynamic Pricing in Bilateral Relationships: Experimental Evidence." Working paper, 2025.

Eschenbaum N, Greber N. "Repeated Auctions with Speculators: Arbitrage Incentives and Forks in DAOs." 2025. link

Eschenbaum N, Mellgren F, Zahn P. "Robust Algorithmic Collusion." 2022 (presented at the NeurIPS 2021 PERLS workshop). link

Eschenbaum N, Liebert H. "Dealing with Uncertainty: The Value of Reputation in the Absence of Legal Institutions." 2021. link

Eschenbaum N. "Estimating Geographic Market Size Nonparametrically: An Application to Grocery Retailing." Working paper, 2018.

Grants and Prizes

2024–2025 **The Market for Foundation Models**. European AI & Society Fund – CHF 50,000 (PI).

2024–2025 **DMA-effects in Switzerland**. Mercator Foundation – CHF 30,000 (co-PI).

2022–2025 **ChartEP: Charting Energy Platforms and Market Outcomes under Varying Policy Measures**. Swiss Federal Office of Energy – CHF 281,215 (PI).

2022 **Young Scholar Award**. CRESSE.

2021–2022 **Computational Learning in Economic Games**. Hasler Foundation – CHF 35,000 (co-PI).

2021–2022 **The Competitive Effects of Pricing Software Systems**. University of St. Gallen – CHF 51,555 (co-PI).

2018–2022 **Pricing in a Digital World**. Swiss National Science Foundation – CHF 500,000, grant no. 178836. Co-wrote the proposal; postdoctoral researcher on the project.

Selected Applied and Policy Work

2026–present Study on modern pricing methods, pricing algorithms, and risks of collusion for the European Commission (DG COMP); leading the competition-economics analysis, in particular on third-party algorithmic pricing.

2025–present Regulatory impact assessment of options for regulating how AI systems use copyright-protected works, for the Swiss Federal Institute of Intellectual Property (IPI).

2025–2026 Regulatory frameworks for financial and digital diversification: AI-assisted comparison of more than 90 countries, identifying what supports or constrains providers of savings and payment services.

2024–2025 Incentive effects of noise charges for late-evening and early-morning flights on airlines' behaviour, with recommendations for the charge design, for an international airport.

2022–2023 Regulatory impact assessment of legal protection for journalistic content online, for the Swiss Federal Institute of Intellectual Property (IPI).

2022 Feasibility study for econometric benchmarking of acute-care hospitals, for a healthcare-sector client.

2022–present Expert reports and economic analysis for parties in proceedings before the Swiss Competition Commission (WEKO) involving information exchange and cartel allegations, including in the retail sector: econometric analysis of price data and pass-on, and assessment of the information exchanged.

2023–2025 Lead economic analysis for a car-finance provider in WEKO cartel proceedings concerning interest rates.

2024–2025 Market definition and competitive assessment for a major digital platform.

2023 Consulted on pricing algorithms for the market-definition work in the review of a major cross-border merger.

2022–2023	Expert work in proceedings on relative market power under the Cartel Act provisions in force since 2022: alternative sources of supply, effects on consumers, and objective justification, including analysis of international price differences.
2026–present	APPRAISE: a roadmap of regulatory measures for integrating renewables, triggered by measurable technical indicators rather than fixed dates; analysis of how prosumers and local energy communities respond to the rules, for the Swiss Federal Office of Energy (SFOE).
2025–present	Research project with Swiss universities and major market participants quantifying the economic value of cross-border electricity trading for Switzerland, including what self-sufficiency would cost.
2024–2025	Bidding and coordination analysis in secondary reserve power markets.
2024–2025	Assessment of reserve power requirements in Switzerland and neighbouring countries, for the Federal Electricity Commission (ElCom).
2022–2025	Market-power analysis for energy trading platforms using multi-agent deep reinforcement learning, ChartEP project for the Swiss Federal Office of Energy (SFOE).
2023–2024	Price-elasticity estimation in German wholesale and end-user energy markets, *Wirtschaftspolitik* Nr. 47, State Secretariat for Economic Affairs.
2023–2024	Analysis of price formation on the Swiss electricity forward market, including indications of market power, for an energy-market participant.
2022–2023	Opportunity-cost assessment of the bids in Switzerland's first hydropower-reserve auctions, for the Federal Electricity Commission (ElCom).
2022	Review of European measures against high gas and electricity prices and their suitability for Switzerland, for the Swiss Federal Office of Energy (SFOE), as input to the Federal Council's decisions in December 2022.
2023–2024	Incentive analysis and mechanism design for a Web3 platform.
2024	Game-theoretic and agent-based analysis of issuance-curve effects on staking behaviour.

Recent Talks and Presentations

2026	Talk, EURO Working Group on Revenue Management & Pricing workshop, Barcelona (December).
2026	Panellist, "The Next Wave of Tech Enforcement: Global Trends in Regulating Platforms and Algorithms," AIJA 13th Antitrust Annual Conference, Düsseldorf.
2026	"Market Power and Platform Design in Decentralized Electricity Trading," EARIE Annual Conference, Mannheim.
2026	"Algorithmic Pricing in Practice and Collusion," ASCOLA Annual Conference, London.
2026	Invited talk on the DMA's impact for Switzerland, State Secretariat for Economic Affairs (SECO), Bern.

2026 "Economic perspectives on market power in AI markets," ASCOLA Working Group on AI/Algorithms workshop.

2026 Invited guest lecture, course "Digitale Ökonomie" (Prof. R. Kesler), Düsseldorf Institute for Competition Economics (DICE).

2025 "Simulating local energy platforms using multi-agent deep hedging," SAEE 2025, ETH Zurich (November).

2025 "Optimale Strategien für dezentrale Prosumenten auf lokalen Energiehandelsplattformen," BKW AG (October).

2025 "Multi-Agent Deep Hedging zur Simulation dezentraler Prosumenten," Axpo AG (September).

2025 "Effizienzverteidigung in der Praxis," Studienvereinigung Kartellrecht (May).